

MORE THAN ONE

*Spreading Plural Awareness by
Sharing Plural Experiences*

ISSUE #002: PLURAL DIVERSITY

PLURAL DIVERSITY: THE MANY WAYS TO BE

MORE-THAN-ONE

By the Fencer Hivemind

The plural community is very diverse, in that there are numerous different ways to *be* plural. Systems can be formed and function a number of different ways, have any number of headmates with different levels of connection and similarity to one another, and view their own plurality through one or more of many different lenses. This issue seeks to explore and celebrate that diversity.

Origins

A system's origin, or the cause of their plurality, is often seen as an important part of their collective identity. The most widely known and well-studied forms of plurality, such as DID and related disorders, are generally traumagenic, meaning caused by trauma, particularly in early childhood, but this is by no means the only way a system can form. Some systems are created, on purpose like by tulpamancy, or sometimes on accident (often by writing or rp). Some systems ascribe their origins to any of a number of spiritual beliefs. Others were simply born plural and require no other explanation. There are many microlabels for different origins, but endogenic is often used as a blanket term for systems whose origin was literally anything other than trauma. Systems can also have multiple origins, so there isn't exactly as clear a divide between traumagenic and endogenic as the prevalence of these terms in the community might suggest.

Alter– Synonym of headmate, most commonly used by disordered systems.

Dormancy– A headmate becoming inactive for a lengthy period of time; exact definitions may vary.

Headspace– A visualization or mental area for headmates interact with one another and exist in while not fronting. Some systems create headspaces deliberately as a useful tool, while some systems have one that was created subconsciously. While having a headspace is common in the plural community, not all systems have one, and you don't need to be plural to have or create a headspace.

Fronting room– An area of the headspace where headmates who are currently fronting are. Often described as like a control room for the body.

Possessive switch– Switches where both headmates maintain separate senses of consciousness while which one is in control changes.

HELPFUL VOCABULARY

Tulpa– A term used to describe headmates that were created, either accidentally or deliberately, usually through repeated interaction and various other techniques. This term was borrowed from Tibetan “sprul pa”, referring to a Tibetan Buddhist spiritual practice. Tulpas as a concept derive more from western Spiritualism, and the term has since undergone shifts in meaning. Most modern tulpas and tulpamancers see tulpas as a psychological phenomenon, where the brain is essentially trained to think as separate entities, rather than a spiritual one. Sprul pa are still an important concept in Tibetan Buddhism, so it is important to note that despite being etymologically related the two terms and the practices surrounding them are very different.

Tulpamancer– Someone who creates a tulpa.

Tulpamancy– The process/practice of creating a tulpa.

DID– Dissociative Identity Disorder. See DSM or ICD for diagnostic criteria. See did-research.org for further information and related disorders.

Disordered v. Non-Disordered

Disordered systems are systems with a dissociative disorder such as DID, OSDD-1, DDNOS, or pDID. In order to have one of these disorders, a system’s plurality, or related dissociation and amnesia, has to cause them distress or dysfunction. This criterion exists to separate disorders from marginalized identities. There’s significant overlap between disordered and traumagenic systems and non-disordered and endogenic systems, but these terms aren’t interchangeable, even if they sometimes get used that way. A system can have multiple origins, and be both traumagenic and endogenic, but can’t be both disordered and non-disordered. Additionally, not all traumagenic systems experience distress or dysfunction related to their plurality, and there are disordered systems with spiritual beliefs surrounding their plurality, or whose plurality predates the trauma that caused their disorder.

Median and More!

Regardless of origin or disordered status, there are many different ways to be plural. Median or midcontinuum systems, for example, are somewhere between fully multiple and fully single on the plural spectrum, often having much less distinct headmates. In some systems, all members are different versions or aspects of the same person, but separate enough to interact with one another. Some systems always have one headmate in control, while others have no main fronter whatsoever. Some systems have just a few members, while others have thousands or more, often in complex structures of layered subsystems.

SYSTEM STORIES

Prompt: Write about how your system works/is structured/was formed and how that looks in your day-to-day life.

It works in cycles! The 1st cycle was more messy, there were a ton of alters that would form and never front again, some that would front for a few minutes and one that fronted for 3 hours straight! What's most peculiar about this one is that 1 alter caused it to explode from 5 alters to 25+. The second one was a little more strange, considering that it was median. Switches wouldn't be like fading out and the other one fading in, it would be like fading into the other one (think about it like powerpoint transitions). I can't say much about this cycle, tho :(

-Kris/weirdosona

QUESTIONS ABOUT PLURALITY?

*Email them to
thefencerhivemind@gmail.com or
submit them anonymously by
scanning the QR code below!*



ASK-A-SYSTEM!

Questions submitted anonymously. Answers provided by the Fencer Hivemind.

Q: *Is Tulpamancy a form of plurality???*

A: *Yep! While the tulpamancy community is sort of its own thing with a history separate from the broader plural community, it does fall under the umbrella of plurality, and there are plenty of tulpamancers and tulpas that are active in the broader plural community as well.*

Honestly, we could probably write a whole book on this prompt. We have actually tried, several times. We're mixed origins, which means (at least in our case) that there's no one root cause of our plurality, but rather a combination of factors that contributed. Despite being partially traumagenic, we're non-disordered, meaning we don't have DID, OSDD-1, pDID, DDNOS, etc. In order for something to be a disorder rather than just a marginalized way of being, it has to cause some level of distress and/or dysfunction, and for us, our plurality just doesn't.

We're a fairly large system. Last I checked the list of headmates we're aware of is around a hundred, and I know for a fact that list is missing quite a few headmates who don't front as much. We have maybe 20-30 headmates that front fairly regularly. Admittedly, not all of those headmates are fully "fleshed out".

For us, when a new headmate forms, they tend to start out fairly flat, and then gain a more complex personality and sense of self by fronting and interacting with other headmates. A lot of our members are sort of halfway between a fully-fledged headmate and like, a bundle of a couple emotions, ideas, and memories. We call these guys wisps.

As for how our system functions on a day to day level, we almost always have multiple headmates in front. Switches aren't usually super noticeable, because usually different headmates pop in and out of front throughout the day. It takes active effort to tell who's in front, and some headmates are better at it than others.

We're monoconscious, so switching in or out feels less like losing control or taking over and more like becoming a different headmate. Our sense of identity, likes and dislikes, interests, habits, and emotions around certain people or events will change depending on who's in front, but our sense of self remains the same. For example, one of my headmates was fronting earlier today, and I remember everything that happened as if it were from my own perspective.

We don't have any amnesia barriers between headmates. Sometimes our working memory will get cleared out when someone switches in or out, and we'll forget why we walked into a room or something, but we have ADHD, so that can happen whenever we get distracted, whether or not it was by a switch.

We do, however, have an amnesia barrier between front and the rest of the headspace. We call it the veil. It's probably easiest to explain with an example. Anyone in front can access the headspace with enough

NOW ACCEPTING SUBMISSIONS FOR

ISSUE 3: PLURALITY IN MEDIA!

Deadline: May 25th, 2026

Instructions for submitting: Email your submission, along with whatever name or pseudonym you wish to go by, to thefencerhivemind@gmail.com. You may also request for your submission to be anonymous.

Question: What's one idea you really like for a plural character or plurality-centric story (TV show, movie, book, whatever)?

System Stories Prompt: Tell us about your favorite plural character (whether you think they were written that way intentionally or not).

Art- Art may be related to this issue's topic if you want, but it is not a requirement.

We're looking for as wide an array of plural perspectives as possible! All systems, including questioning systems, are welcome to submit!

There are a couple things, actually! For starters, we're a pretty big system, with a fairly complicated structure and lots of subsystems within subsystems. On top of that, we usually have multiple headmates in control at once. Right now, for example Kay is mostly in control of the body, while Sam types and I (Aliana) internally dictate what we want to say. We visualize our fronting "room" as basically a pavilion in the center of our headspace, with how often different headmates wander in and out.

-The Fencer Hivemind

concentration, like with visualization-based meditating. If I were to enter the headspace right now, I would be in our fronting room. If I wanted to talk to another headmate, say, Joe, I could leave the formal "fronting room" to go the tavern where he usually hangs out, but I'd still be in front, on the fronting side of the veil, and go back to the fronting room whenever I loose focus.

If I were to have a conversation with Joe like this, he'd stay on the headspace side of the veil unless he chose to join me in front. Whenever Joe ends up in front next, he'll remember the conversation, but only from my perspective, just like everyone else in the system. He won't remember his own perspective, or anything he was doing in the headspace while not fronting. People who aren't in front still seem to be able to access at least some memories from the front, but it's hard to tell to what extent, for obvious reasons.

-Aliana & Sam, the Fencer Hivemind

My collective doesn't have a headspace or innerworld so in the day to day, goings on happen based on who is fronting or is near front or is somehow interacting with front. This is what I'll try to describe.

Oftentimes, my brain gives the current fronter the illusion that they're by themself or is blurred into "one"

self but in times of stress or need, my collective differentiates into the different parts to deal with the issue or conflict. This can be experienced as moving quickly between different parts who are all floating near the front or who are able to communicate with front somehow even if they aren't in it.

Another experience of how my collective works is that strong triggers can cause possessive switches.

Typically, changing from one fronter to another is slow and not noticeable by the collective but in times where there is a strong trigger – either negative or positive – it's almost instantaneous and can feel quite jarring.

Essentially, my collective functions by attempting to work as one individual. Below the surface of awareness, different parts and levers are pulled or pushed in such a way that it gives the illusion of a singular self. However, this illusion is breached either due to times of extreme stress or when taking meticulous records of internal goings-on. I would say my experience is very much like trying to look at your own eyes with those same eyes. My experience is not objective or consistent but confusing and deceptive.

–Anonymous

(EDITOR'S NOTE: The comic on the following page is from the same contributor and was intended to go along with this explanation).

What's one unique or unusual thing about your system?

1st cycle: The amnesia barriers would weaken with time.

2nd cycle: A splinter's s/o went dormant? I think? We call it "going under the door mat" :P

3rd cycle: The other alter is from a source I don't even consume, I just know some things about it due to curiosity.

–Kris/weirdosona

My experience of plurality fluctuates and is dependent on who's fronting.

–Anonymous

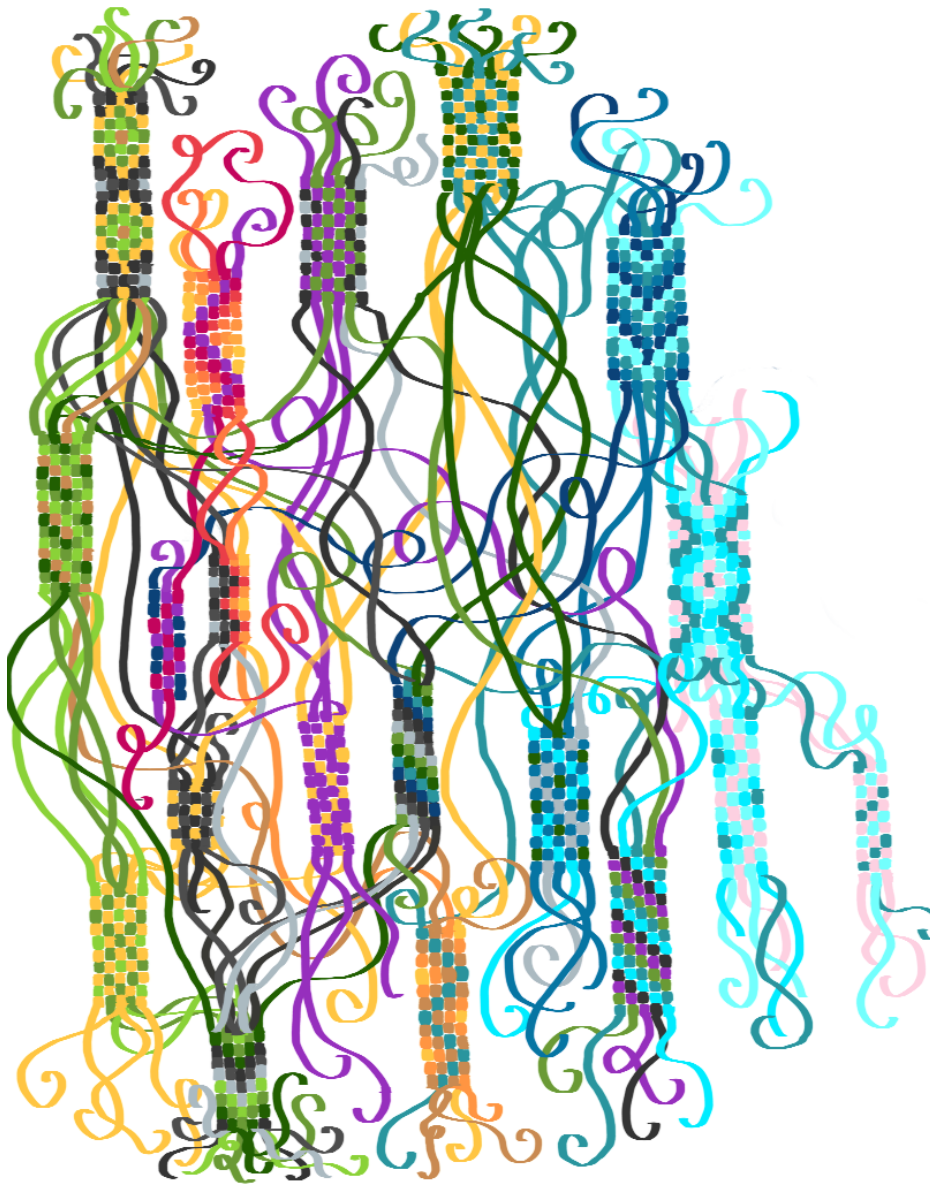


Illustration by the Fencer Hivemind

PLURAL ART



Comic made by Anonymous to go alongside their prose contribution.



Drawing by
Kris/weirdosona showing
themselves in all three
cycles: Kris (upper left),
Kodo (below), and Zeph
(upper right)

